Lesson 09 material: Thinking and Learning: Discussion, Listening and Reading

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 1: Academic Writing Essentials · Psychology

3.1: Discussion

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Answer the following questions based on your experience and opinion. Read five classmates' posts and respond to two classmates pointing out any similarities or differences, asking clarifying questions, or giving your opinion on a point they make.

1. What resources do you use to improve your learning? The resources might be on campus, at your home, or on the internet.
2. What do you do when you do not understand a topic? What do you do when you are confused about a topic?

3.2: Listening-5 Tips to Improve Your Critical Thinking

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

1.3.2.1. Exercise 1-Listening Comprehension

Watch the video 5 Tips to Improve Your Critical Thinking and build a basic understanding to prepare you for this chapter's reading. Answer the questions to check your comprehension.

1. What is one advantage of critical thinking?
a. It's a process that helps us make only large, important decisions
b. It's a process that helps us make only small, unimportant decisions
c. It's a process that helps us create hidden issues, bias and manipulation
d. It's a process that helps us reveal hidden issues, bias and manipulation
2. What is the first step (of five) in the critical thinking process?
a. Gather information
b. Apply information
c. Formulate questions
d. Consider implications
3. When making a decision, what is the main purpose of gathering facts and information?
a. To make sure your assumptions are illogical
b. To weigh out various options or choices
c. To ignore the implications of your choices
d. To explore your own perspective and point of view
4. Considering the implications of a decision means:
a. Examining its potential outcomes and effects
b. Asking questions to determine your goal
c. Gathering information to weight out options
d. Determining whether information is logical
5. How can critical thinking improve your chances of making better choices?
a. Critical thinking helps you pick the correct and best choice for all situations
b. Critical thinking helps you explore only your own perspective and no others
c. Critical thinking helps you examine information and make unreasonable choices
d. Critical thinking provides you the tools to sift through complex information logically

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Links on the original page

- 5 Tips to Improve Your Critical Thinking: https://ed.ted.com/lessons/5-tips-to-improve-your-critical-thinking-samantha-agoos

3.3: Reading-The Value of Confusion

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

1.3.3.1. Exercise 2-Reading Comprehension

Read the passage below and answer the questions that follow.

1We've all felt confused before, and it can be one of the most frustrating feelings to deal with. Students might be confused about how to do a math problem or finish a project. Young people might be confused about who they are and what to do in the future. No matter what is making us confused, the feeling of not knowing what the answers or solutions are can make us feel useless, stupid, and cause us to worry.

2A lot of people are hard on themselves and others when there's a lack of understanding. People often tend to think the person who has all of the answers is smarter than the one who asks a lot of questions. Because of the negative judgment that surrounds confusion, people often try to hide their confusion in a variety of ways. Instead of admitting or accepting that they don't have the solution, people sometimes try to pretend they have the answers. At other times, people make educated guesses or make up an answer even if they know it isn't right.

3Students are often guilty of hiding their lack of understanding. If confused about a topic in school, they might pretend to know the answers. They can sometimes be embarrassed to ask questions. As young individuals, they can be confused about who they are, and might try harder to behave in a particular way. They can be too embarrassed to explore other groups or identities, afraid perhaps of being called a "wanna-be". They can be afraid people will know they're confused.

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4But confusion might actually be a good thing. When we jump to an answer, we don't have time to explore and understand the thing we're confused about. Fighting confusion ends up making us more confused. Instead of fighting or trying to ignore your confusion, accepting it and taking the opportunity to analyze what's confusing can benefit our learning. In fact, scientific studies show that confusion actually leads to deeper understanding. A 2004 study explored six moods that people feel while learning, including frustrated, bored, and confused. They found that students who spent more of the lesson confused learned the most. In another study, published in 2014, scientists tried to confuse students by giving them contradicting information. Students who expressed confusion during the lesson did better on the final test. Based on these studies, scientists believe being confused is a step to learning. Not knowing the answer to a problem gives us space to look at different ways to solve it. The feeling of confusion also motivates us to look more deeply into the problem. In the end, this helps us understand the topic on a deeper level.

5Confusion isn't just an important step to learning in school, it's also important for learning who you are. Psychologists call that sense of who you are identity. Your identity can involve being part of groups like race, gender, subcultures. Identity is also made up of your values and goals. People figure out their identity in two steps. The first step is exploration, where you try out different groups and values and see what fits. The next step is commitment, when you decide firmly about some parts of your identity. Exploring your identity can feel very confusing. You might be afraid that people will judge you for going through different phases or not committing to a group. But phases are completely natural. A study published in the International Journal of Behavioral Development found that people who do the most exploring about who they are have better outcomes such as higher self-esteem later in life. Confusion gives us the space to try new things and be creative. Allowing ourselves to be confused and ask questions leads to deeper understanding, more learning, and higher self-confidence. So, try not to be embarrassed when you're confused about something. Instead of trying to hide or fight your confusion, try to resolve it by trying new things. Embrace the confusion and explore different solutions to your problem. Sometimes being confused is hard, not just because we judge ourselves, but because it can be frustrating. When we try over and over to understand something without making any progress, we can feel defeated and stop caring, and eventually give up. Trying a new method, asking for help, or researching different ways to approach the problem online can all be great resources to work through your confusion. Before you give up, make sure you have someone to help you and the resources you need to resolve your confusion.

1. PART A: Which statement best expresses the central ideas of the text?

a. Allowing yourself to feel confused is a necessary part of developing your brain and understanding yourself.
b. Confusion is more important to intellectual growth than it is to understanding your identity.
c. It takes a certain degree of self-confidence and maturity to admit that you don't have all the answers.
d. Feeling confused is something that will fade with time and experience as you acquire all of the answers.

2. PART B: Which detail from the text best supports the answer to Part A?

a. “No matter what is making us confused, the feeling of not knowing what the answers or solutions are can make us feel useless, stupid, and cause us to worry.” (Paragraph 1)

b. “Instead of admitting or accepting that they don’t have the solution, people sometimes try to pretend they have the answers.” (Paragraph 2)

c. “Students are often guilty of hiding their lack of understanding. If confused about a topic in school, they might pretend to know the answers.” (Paragraph 3)

d. “Confusion isn’t just an important step to learning in school, it’s also important for learning who you are.” (Paragraph 5)

3. PART A: Which of the following describes the author’s main purpose in the text?

a. to provide readers with tools to overcome their confusion

b. to reassure readers that it’s completely normal to feel confused

c. to encourage readers to work through their confusion, rather than avoid it

d. to explore why teenagers are more susceptible to confusion than adults

4. PART B: Which quote from the text best supports the answer to Part A?

a. “We’ve all felt confused before, and it can be one of the most frustrating feelings to deal with.” (Paragraph 1)

b. “As young individuals they can be confused about who they are, and might try harder to behave in a particular way.” (Paragraph 3)

c. “A 2004 study explored six moods that people feel while learning, including frustrated, bored, and confused.” (Paragraph 4)

d. “Instead of trying to hide or fight your confusion, try to resolve it by trying new things.” (Paragraph 5)

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Links on the original page

- The Value of Being Confused: https://www.commonlit.org/en/texts/the-value-of-being-confused
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16.3: Chapter 3

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4.3.1. Listening Comprehension

00:11 Every day, a sea of decisions stretches before us.

00:15 Some are small and unimportant,

00:17 but others have a larger impact on our lives.

00:19 For example, which politician should I vote for?

00:22 Should I try the latest diet craze?

00:24 Or will email make me a millionaire?

00:27 We're bombarded with so many decisions

00:30 that it's impossible to make a perfect choice every time.

00:33 But there are many ways to improve our chances,

00:36 and one particularly effective technique is critical thinking.

00:40 This is a way of approaching a question

00:42 that allows us to carefully deconstruct a situation,

00:45 reveal its hidden issues, such as bias and manipulation,

00:48 and make the best decision.

00:51 If the critical part sounds negative that's because in a way it is.

00:56 Rather than choosing an answer because it feels right,

00:58 a person who uses critical thinking

01:00 subjects all available options to scrutiny and skepticism.

01:05 Using the tools at their disposal,

01:06 they'll eliminate everything but the most useful and reliable information.

01:11 There are many different ways of approaching critical thinking,

01:15 but here's one five-step process

01:17 that may help you solve any number of problems.

01:21 One: formulate your question.

01:23 In other words, know what you're looking for.

01:26 This isn't always as straightforward as it sounds.

01:29 For example, if you're deciding whether to try out the newest diet craze,

01:33 your reasons for doing so may be obscured by other factors,

01:37 like claims that you'll see results in just two weeks.

01:40 But if you approach the situation

01:42 with a clear view of what you're actually trying to accomplish by dieting,

01:46 whether that's weight loss,

01:48 better nutrition,

01:49 or having more energy,

01:50 that'll equip you to sift through this information critically,

01:54 find what you're looking for,

01:55 and decide whether the new fad really suits your needs.

02:00 Two: gather your information.

02:03 There's lots of it out there,

02:05 so having a clear idea of your question will help you determine what's relevant.

02:09 If you're trying to decide on a diet to improve your nutrition,

02:12 you may ask an expert for their advice,

02:14 or seek other people's testimonies.

02:16 Information gathering helps you weigh different options,

02:19 moving you closer to a decision that meets your goal.

02:23 Three: apply the information,

02:25 something you do by asking critical questions.

02:29 Facing a decision, ask yourself, "What concepts are at work?"

02:32 "What assumptions exist?"

02:34 "Is my interpretation of the information logically sound?"

02:38 For example, in an email that promises you millions,

02:41 you should consider, "What is shaping my approach to this situation?"

02:45 "Do I assume the sender is telling the truth?"

02:48 "Based on the evidence, is it logical to assume I'll win any money?"

02:54 Four: consider the implications.

02:56 Imagine it's election time,

02:58 and you've selected a political candidate based on their promise

03:01 to make it cheaper for drivers to fill up on gas.

03:04 At first glance, that seems great.

03:06 But what about the long-term environmental effects?

03:09 If gasoline use is less restricted by cost,

03:12 this could also cause a huge surge in air pollution,

03:16 an unintended consequence that's important to think about.

03:20 Five: explore other points of view.

03:23 Ask yourself why so many people are drawn

03:26 to the policies of the opposing political candidate.

03:29 Even if you disagree with everything that candidate says,

03:32 exploring the full spectrum of viewpoints

03:34 might explain why some policies that don't seem valid to you appeal to others.

03:40 This will allow you to explore alternatives,

03:42 evaluate your own choices,

03:44 and ultimately help you make more informed decisions.

03:48 This five-step process is just one tool,

03:51 and it certainly won't eradicate difficult decisions from our lives.

03:55 But it can help us increase the number of positive choices we make.

04:00 Critical thinking can give us the tools to sift through a sea of information

04:04 and find what we're looking for.

04:06 And if enough of us use it,

04:07 it has the power to make the world a more reasonable place.

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